



Paraguay



Landlocked in central South America, and once a Spanish colony, Paraguay's postindependence history has included periods of military rule. Free elections were held in 1993.



GEOGRAPHY

The Paraguay River divides the hilly and forested east from a flat alluvial plain, with marsh and semidesert scrub land in the west.



CLIMATE

Subtropical. The Gran Chaco is generally hotter and drier. All areas experience floods and droughts.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Population mainly of mixed Spanish and native Guaraní origin. Most people are bilingual, though in rural areas Guaraní is more widely used. Cattle ranchers populate the Chaco, along with communities of the German-origin Mennonite Church. The army is politically active.



INSIGHT: *The War of the Triple Alliance (1864–1870) killed almost 90% of Paraguay's male population*



THE ECONOMY

Agriculture: soybeans are the main export. Electricity exported from massive hydroelectric dams, including Itaipú (world's second-largest, jointly run with Brazil). Large informal economy. Corruption and smuggling.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Paraguay

DATE OF FORMATION: 1811

CAPITAL: Asunción

POPULATION: 6.35 million

TOTAL AREA: 157,046 sq. miles
(406,750 sq. km)

DENSITY: 41 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Guaraní*, Spanish*, German

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 96%, Protestant (including Mennonite) 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 91%, other 7%, Amerindian 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Guaraní = 100 céntimos